# Step Four of Nine

## Where the planning step sits when you're preparing ahead for Mom's care.

You've read about care, about finances, about Medicaid, and it's hard to tell how the pieces connect or which one your family is on. They connect in an order, and when there's time you can take them one at a time.

This page shows the nine steps, where the planning step sits among them, what it draws on, and who is involved after it.

### Phase 1 · Assess

Understand where you are today.

1. **Understand** Care Needs → Levels of Care & Costs → Care Plan
   You finish with: Future Care Planning Assessment
2. **Organize** Income & Assets → Ownership & Expenses → Financial File
   You finish with: Family Financial Inventory
3. **Assess** Care & Nonfinancial Eligibility → Income & Assets → Barriers & Readiness
   You finish with: Medicaid Readiness Assessment

### Phase 2 · Plan

Develop and implement your strategy.

4. **Plan** Barriers & Issues → Priorities & Professional Team → Written Plan
   You finish with: Advance Medicaid Planning Roadmap

   **You are here.** This is the step where the first three come together. What you've learned about Mom's care needs, the financial picture you've organized and where things stand with Medicaid are brought into one written plan showing what can be done now, what should be monitored, and what events would trigger action.
5. **Legal** Authority & Documents → Property, Trusts & Transfers → Attorney Review
   You finish with: Legal Planning Review
6. **Financial** Costs & Runway → Asset Treatment & Tools → Strategy & Documentation
   You finish with: Long-Term Care Funding Plan

### Phase 3 · Secure

Secure benefits, protect assets, and maintain eligibility.

7. **Apply** Prepare → Submit → Manage
   You finish with: Medicaid Application-Ready File
8. **Protect** What May Be Protected → What May Remain Exposed → What Needs Ongoing Attention
   You finish with: Asset Protection Assessment

9 **Maintain** Ongoing Requirements → Changes & Renewals → Maintenance System

You finish with: Medicaid Monitoring & Maintenance System

## What this step draws on

The three steps before it: a picture of the care Mom needs and wants, her finances gathered into one file, and a look at where things stand with Medicaid. A family planning ahead often arrives with some of these half done. That's ordinary, and bringing the pieces together is how you see which ones are thin.

## What this step produces

A written long-term-care and Medicaid plan for your family: what can be done now, what should be monitored, and what events would trigger action. It is built in the course with your Medicaid planner, moving from the issues to look at, to priorities and the professional team, to the written plan. A page like this one doesn't produce it, and neither do a family's notes.

## What happens next

Two steps finish this phase, Legal and Financial, and each belongs to a licensed professional. The Administration for Community Living describes an elder law attorney's work as helping create a legal framework so that a person's medical and financial wishes are fulfilled. The planning step is what gets a family ready for those conversations. [1]

The third phase begins with an application, if one is ever made. Whether a person is eligible is the state's to decide: the Administration for Community Living explains that the states operate Medicaid day to day, including taking applications and making determinations of eligibility. For a family planning ahead, the written plan is reviewed on a schedule in the meantime. [2]

## Who is involved, by role

- You and your family: gathering, writing down, noticing, and talking over who takes part.
- Mom: what she wants, in her own words.
- Your Medicaid planner: brings the family's care needs, preferences, finances, Medicaid-readiness findings and existing legal planning into one picture, helps separate what can be addressed now from what should be monitored, and names the events that should trigger action.
- An elder law attorney: reviews the legal issues.
- A licensed financial professional and a licensed insurance professional: review the issues that belong to them.

**What this page doesn't promise**

How long any step takes, who will be available, or how things turn out. It doesn't say Mom will need Medicaid or would qualify for it. Families planning ahead move through the steps at their own pace. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

## Ready for the next step?

You know where the planning step sits, what it draws on and who is involved after it. The planning interview is one way to begin: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

**Get Your Free Planning Report ›**

**WHERE THIS COMES FROM**

The nine steps are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own. The description of an elder law attorney's work and of how the states run Medicaid comes from the Administration for Community Living.

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Will I Need a Lawyer?
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Applying for Medicaid

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